Science and Sustainability Assignment 1: Information Resources

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Course number and title: 247 111 Science and Sustainability

Title

99.9% of scientists do not agree, but you should buy a book anyway.

Source evaluated

Watts, J. (2021). *'Case closed': 99.9% of scientists agree climate emergency caused by humans.*

https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2021/oct/19/case-closed-999-of-scientists-agree-climate-emergency-caused-by-humans

Summary of your source

The Guardian article constructs a narrative about an impending climate crisis on the basis of a non-existent consensus within the scientific community. Claiming that the 'climate emergency' is human caused. It support this claim by citing a literature review of 90,000 studies and other Guardian articles on the same and similar topics. Focusing mostly on the literature review journal paper by Lynas et al, the article is primarily publicity for the authors. Reiterating their points, misrepresenting the paper and presenting a highly biassed piece of scaremongering while subtly advertising Lynas's new book, ominously titled 'Our final warning'.

Source evaluation using CRAAP criteria:

Currency: 3

The article is current, being written in 2021. However, for a newspaper this is not breaking news and to this end the article displays a banner in the page header warning the age is greater than one year. All the links are working, bar one. The broken link being to a paper by Lynas et al in Environmental Research Letters, but which is itself a duplicate link to the initial source. Since publishing the data set of 90,000 has been removed. Overall, the content is current, given the article revolves around Lynas' work.

Relevance: 0

Mostly women fifteen and over within the United Kingdom read the Guardian, according to Watson (2022). The article is not overtly targeted to women. Its content is relevant to the

topic of climate action, albeit intensely myopic; focusing on work by Mark Lynas and five references to other Guardian articles. In 2021, Lynas released a new book titled 'Our final warning' (Lynas, 2021). 60% of book purchasers are women (Schmidt and Park, 2013).

3.1

Reading wider is required to understand the topic of climate action. Perhaps Lynas's book? The article is more relevant as marketing for Lynas than to climate action.

Authority: 0

Jonathan Watts is the Guardian's global environmental editor, writer/editor of 3,663 articles (The Guardian, 2023). He does not claim scientific credentials. The focal paper is by Mark Lynas, Benjamin Z Houlton and Simon Perry. Lynas, a journalist, writes environmental sensationalism. Claiming scientific authority to sell a catastrophe narrative. From his site: “A small battle won for team science – every small victory should be celebrated in these dark days” (Lynas, 2023). Houlton is a credible scientist from Cornell University of 121 papers (Researchgate, 2023). While Perry is not, having only this paper (Researchgate, 2023). This article has overall, low authority.

3.2

3.3

Accuracy: 0

The Guardian and Lynas et al claim 99% consensus in their titles. Only 19/2718 papers endorse human caused climate change (Lynas, 2021). The 99% consensus is the confidence interval of 99.62% – 99.96% for keywords inferring paper topics. While the reported 99.99% of the Guardian is from the confidence level of 99.999%. A data set of 85,000 is no longer available, was not used in the work's results, but was cited by the Guardian. The Guardian also states that “a previous study showed 97% [consensus]” (Watts, 2021), while failing to provide a reference. The article is not accurate.

3.4

Purpose: 0

Given the language of the article and the lack of references, the article has two purposes; to enflame public opinion about a climate emergency and to publicise the work of Lynas. This angle is supported by Lynas when he promoted the misrepresentation of his data by the Guardian on the Reliable sou podcast falsely concluding off critics of his work that “undermining the case for action on climate change is not based on science” (Stelter, 2021). One need only look at the titles of each; the Guardian uses “climate emergency” while Lynas et al use “human caused climate change”.

3.5

3.6

Conclusion of evaluation

Overall this article fails the CRAAP test with a score of 3/15. It publicises inaccurate work while simultaneously misrepresenting it. Some might say, in a typical manner for a newspaper outlet; reporting the wrong number wrongly. Written by an editor, it escapes editorial scrutiny. Rather than an informative article, it is perhaps more likely to be marketing for another book by Mark Lynas. This source should be viewed with extreme caution and not taken as an authoritative source for any factual information.

4.1

Reference for source in APA format

Watson, A. (2022, February 4). *Monthly reach of The Guardian in the United Kingdom from April 2019 to March 2020, by demographic group.*

https://www.statista.com/statistics/380687/the-guardian-the-observer-monthly-reach-by-demographic-uk/

4.2

Lynas, M. (2021). *Our Final Warning: Six Degrees of Climate Emergency Paperback*. **Fourth Estate**

Schmidt, M. Park, M. (2013, June). *Trends in Consumer Book Buying [Infographic]*

https://authornews.penguinrandomhouse.com/trends-in-consumer-book-buying-infographic/

The Guardian. (2023). *Jonathan Watts.*

4.3

https://www.theguardian.com/profile/jonathanwatts

Lynas, M. (2023). *Mark Lynas*.

https://marklynas.org/

ResearchGate. (2023). *Benjamin Z. Houlton's research while affiliated with Cornell University and other places.*

https://www.researchgate.net/scientific-contributions/Benjamin-Z-Houlton-14774111

ResearchGate. (2023). *Simon Perry's research while affiliated with Santa Fe Alliance for Science and other places*.

https://www.researchgate.net/scientific-contributions/Simon-Perry-2204697451

Stleter, B. (Host). (2021, October 22). Reliable Sources. [Audio podcast episode]. *Climate expert Mark Lynas on the 'final nail in the coffin' of climate denial; media coverage of COP26; and more.*

https://omny.fm/shows/reliable-sources-with-brian-stelter/climate-expert-mark-lynas-on-the-final-nail-in-the

Assignment 1 – self assessment check list. Mark your self-assessment for each achievement criteria with an x in the highlighted table cell.

Achievement criteria	**D**	**C**	**B**	**A**

1.1.1 – Critically evaluate information using the CRAAP framework	Elements of framework missing	All elements of framework addressed BUT does not identify why aspects may be problematic	All elements of framework addressed in a way that clearly identifies why/how criteria are credible or not	All elements of framework fully addressed in a way that integrates the different parts of the framework, identifying embedded or implicit issues and addressing their relationships to each other
				X

Summarise **a source of information in your own words**	Missess critical points, OR No restructuring of knowledge, OR Inclusion of irrelevant information, OR Inaccurate restructuring	Captures most of the main points with attempt at restructuring, OR Captures all the main points but without substantively restructuring	Key concepts are captured with evidence of restructured knowledge – e.g. own words, own structure	Key concepts are communicated clearly and succinctly AND ideas are fully restructured from source materials

				X
Use **evidence appropriately to substantiate ideas**	No evidence provided to substantiate CRAAP evaluations	Some evidence provided, but inconsistently across CRAAP criteria	Evidence provided to support CRAAP evaluations for all criteria	Evidence provided to support CRAAP evaluations for all criteria AND credibility of evidence is considered
				X
1.2.2 –	Sources	Reference	Attempted	Accurate

Use appropriate referencing style	not referenced	not in appropriate format	use of APA7 format, but with minor errors	reference provided in APA 7 format
				X

Index of comments

2.1 This is an analysis of what is in the article. A summary is a summary of the key points. This should be stand alone to the article.

2.2 I think this is a bit farm. The Guardian article has written a summary piece drawing attention to a recently published peer reviewed article.

2.3 The link works for me?
The article you are critiquing is about a published article. As long as the published article remains current then your source is current. But this does really depend on what you are looking for.

3.1 I'm not sure what you are talking about here. Relevance pertains to what you were looking for. What was your search topic? How relevant was this source? Think level of detail.

3.2 Did you look for him on LinkedIn or search other sources?

3.3 You're look at the authority of Watts to write about the paper by Lynas et al. You're not questioning the authority of Lynas.

3.4 Not really sure what you are saying here. You need to establish that Watts accurately describes what Lynas et al wrote. Check the links. Make sure the editor got the reporting right. this will be at a high level, as the Guardian article won't repeat all the complexity.

3.5 I'd agree with this.

3.6 OK this is good. You've found evidence that Watts did get it wrong!

Did you look into the wider objective of the publication the Guardian?

4.1 Good

4.2 Good. But put these into alphabetical order.

4.3 This is the reference, but format is wrong. Should be author (year) title, source. Use OWLL to make sure you are right.